the document. It defined the missile forces as the “backbone for the defense of the Soviet Union and the island of Cuba,” and ordered them to be “prepared, upon signal from Moscow, to deal a nuclear missile strike to the most important targets in the United States of America.” The American sites were also to be targeted by nuclear submarines to be sent to Cuba as part of the Soviet Navy.[12]

The instruction to Pliev clearly stated that the nuclear weapons, both tactical and strategic, could be used only upon receiving an order from Moscow, meaning from Khrushchev himself. But the General Staff was also considering the possibility of giving Pliev the right to decide on his own whether to use such weapons in case of invasion. On September 8, the day on which the main instruction was signed, someone in the General Staff drafted an additional instruction that would apply if contact between Havana and Moscow became impossible.

The new instruction read: “In a situation of an enemy landing on the island of Cuba and of the concentration of enemy ships with amphibious forces off the coast of Cuba in its territorial waters, when the destruction of the enemy is delaying [further actions] and there is no possibility of receiving instructions from the USSR Ministry of Defense, you are permitted to make your own decision and to use the nuclear means of the ‘Luna,’ IL-28 or FKR-1 [short-range cruise missiles] as instruments of local warfare for the destruction of the enemy on land and along the coast in order to achieve the complete destruction of the invaders on Cuban territory and to defend the Republic of Cuba.”[13]

The instruction on Pliev’s discretionary use of nuclear weapons without orders from Moscow remained unsigned by Malinovsky. Khrushchev was not yet prepared to relinquish his personal control of nuclear weapons, even tactical ones. But the instruction to allow Pliev to do so was ready. Only the signature was missing.

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ON SEPTEMBER 8, THE SAME DAY THAT KHRUSHCHEV APPROVED the new shipment of nuclear arms to Cuba, the White House announced that